Zenaida Papandayan-Ampatua

Bai Zenaida Papandayan-Ampatua is a retired Meranaw educator, school administrator, and royal title holder from Lanao del Sur who spent more than four decades in the Philippine public school system.

She rose from classroom teacher to Schools Division Superintendent, passing the Superintendent's Examination as a topnotcher at just 34 years old, and went on to lead the Division of Lanao Sur II through some of its most formative years.

A daughter of the late Superintendent Mauyag C. Papandayan Sr., she followed her father's footsteps into public service and carried that legacy well beyond it, earning recognition not just as an educator but as a community leader and traditional ruler.

She holds the royal title **Sulutan a Bae sa Biabi**, a distinction conferred by her clan that reflects her lineage from the panoroganan communities of Bayang, Biyabi, Tatarikun, Pagayawan, and Tubaran — all considered noble seats of leadership in the Lake Lanao area.

In 2025, she became the **first recipient of the Bae a Rawaten Award** of the Division of Lanao Sur II, a prestigious recognition given to educators who have made exceptional and lasting contributions to the educational system while exemplifying strong character as a public servant and community figure.

Contents

1 Background and Lineage
2 Education
3 Career
    3.1 Early Years
    3.2 Rising Through the Ranks
    3.3 Leadership of the Division
    3.4 Regional Leadership
4 Recognition and Awards
5 Royal Title and Community Role
6 Personal Life
7 Legacy
8 References

Background and Lineage

Bai Zenaida comes from one of the more storied families in the Ranao educational tradition.

Her father, the late Superintendent Mauyag C. Papandayan Sr., served as Schools Division Superintendent of Lanao Sur II, and Zenaida herself worked under his administration as Planning Officer during the early years of her career.

Her family roots trace back to the noble communities of Bayang, Biyabi, Tatarikun, Pagayawan, and Tubaran — all recognized as panoroganan (traditional seats of governance and prestige) within the Paengampong a Ranao.

This lineage positioned her not just as a civil servant but as a *bae a datumanong sa unayan,* a woman of noble descent from the heartland of Lake Lanao — a standing her community formally recognized by conferring on her the royal title of Sulutan a Bae sa Biabi.

She is married to Hon. Abdillah Ampatua, who served as Municipal Mayor of Bayang, and together they raised seven children, many of whom went on to hold significant public roles in the Bangsamoro region.

Education

Even while serving as a division superintendent, Bai Zenaida continued her own studies, a commitment that speaks to the seriousness with which she treated educational leadership.

She earned her **Master's Degree from Mindanao State University** (MSU), and later completed her **Doctorate in Educational Management from Xavier University** in Cagayan de Oro.

Earning a doctorate while managing a large and complex school division wasn't a small thing, and it underscored the kind of discipline she was known for — balancing the demands of leadership, family, and scholarship at the same time.

Career

Early Years

Bai Zenaida started her career as an **Elementary Classroom Teacher in the Division of Marawi City.**

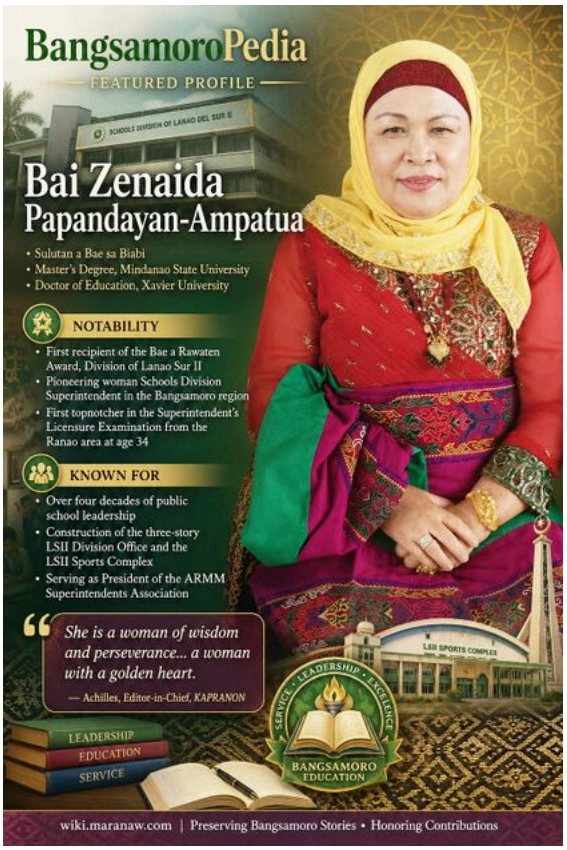
She later transferred to the **Division of Lanao Sur II**, where she took on the role of Music Coordinator, developing a reputation for administrative capability that opened further doors.

She then served as **Planning Officer** under the administration of her father, the late Superintendent Mauyag C. Papandayan Sr., before being promoted to **Science Supervisor.**

Rising Through the Ranks

Her advancement through the division was steady.

Bai Zenaida Papandayan-Ampatua



Personal Information
Born: c. 1954 **Nationality:** Filipino **Ethnicity:** Meranaw **Religion:** Islam
Royal Title
Sulutan a Bae sa Biabi Traditional royal title conferred by her clan and community in the Ranao panoroganan
Education
Master's Degree, Mindanao State University Doctor of Education (Educational Management), Xavier University
Career
Elementary Classroom Teacher, Marawi City Division Music Coordinator, Division of Lanao Sur II Planning Officer, Division of Lanao Sur II Science Supervisor, Division of Lanao Sur II Assistant Schools Division Superintendent, Division of Lanao Sur II Schools Division Superintendent, Division of Lanao Sur II (1988) Schools Division Superintendent, Division of

After her father's retirement, she was promoted to **Assistant Schools Division Superintendent** — and then, in **1988**, she was elevated to **Schools Division Superintendent of the Division of Lanao Sur II**, having passed the Superintendent's Examination as the **topnotcher at the remarkable age of 34.**

That achievement made her one of the youngest and most highly qualified school administrators in the region at the time.

Leadership of the Division

Under her watch, the Division of Lanao Sur II became a **model division in the ARMM** (Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao), recognized for its programs, leadership culture, and physical development.

Among her most tangible accomplishments during this period were the construction of the **LSII Sports Complex** and the three-story **Division Office** — at the time, the most admired division building in the entire ARMM.

Both projects were accomplished despite limited resources, a point often highlighted by those who worked with her during that era.

Before the Division of Lanao Sur II was split into two sub-divisions, Bai Zenaida had already managed the full scope of that large organization.

She later led **Division of Lanao Sur II-A** and then returned to head the original Division in **2008**, this time under the rallying slogan: **"LSII at Its Best."**

Regional Leadership

Her influence extended beyond her own division.

She was elected **President of the ARMM Superintendents Association**, a role that placed her at the center of regional education policy conversations and gave her a platform to advocate for improved standards across all ARMM school divisions.

Lanao Sur II-A Schools Division Superintendent, Division of Lanao Sur II (2008) President, ARMM Superintendents Association
Awards and Recognition
Most Outstanding Public Service Award, Association of Media Outstanding Superintendent Award, Association of SDS First Bae a Rawaten, Division of Lanao Sur II
Family
Spouse: Hon. Abdillah Ampatua, Municipal Mayor of Bayang **Father:** Late Superintendent Mauyag C. Papandayan Sr. **Children:** 7
Notability
First recipient of the Bae a Rawaten Award, Division of Lanao Sur II; pioneering woman Schools Division Superintendent in the Bangsamoro region; first topnotcher in the Superintendent's Licensure Examination from the Ranao area at age 34
Known For
Over four decades of public school leadership; construction of the LSII Division Office (the most admired three-story division building in ARMM) and the LSII Sports Complex; serving as President of the ARMM Superintendents Association; holding the royal title of Sulutan a Bae sa Biabi
Pull Quote
"She is a woman of wisdom and perseverance... a woman with a golden heart." — Achilles, Editor-in-Chief, KAPRANON

She also attended numerous seminars and conferences at the national and international levels, broadening her perspective and bringing back knowledge and best practices to her teams.

Recognition and Awards

Bai Zenaida accumulated a number of awards over the course of her career, including:

- **Most Outstanding Public Service Award** from the Association of Media
- **Outstanding Superintendent Award** from the Association of SDS (Schools Division Superintendents)

- **First Bae a Rawaten Award** of the Division of Lanao Sur II (2025)

The Bae a Rawaten Award is a distinction given to educators who have demonstrated exceptional contributions to educational improvement and who embody strong character as both a professional and a community leader.

Royal Title and Community Role

Beyond her career in public education, Bai Zenaida holds a recognized place in Meranaw society as **Sulutan a Bae sa Biabi.**

This title reflects both her noble lineage and the trust her community places in her as a leader.

Her family connections span several of the Lake Lanao area's most historically significant communities, including Bayang, Biyabi, Tatarikun, Pagayawan, and Tubaran — all panoroganan within the Paengampong a Ranao.

Those who know her describe the title as fitting, pointing to her consistent record of service and her reputation for caring deeply about the people around her.

Personal Life

Bai Zenaida is married to **Hon. Abdillah Ampatua**, who served as Municipal Mayor of Bayang.

They have seven children:

1. **Pisigi**, wife of Hon. Atty. Saadudin Alauya Jr., a former Regional Assemblyman currently working at the MSU System
2. **Mayor Saharodin Maya**
3. **Sandra**, married to Alexie
4. **Tohami**, Protocol Officer, BARMM Parliament
5. **Aliza**, wife of Mayor Hon. Mohammad Aquil Mamaenti and currently serving as DTI Provincial Director
6. **Fahad**
7. **Rajiv**

In retirement, she continues to serve her community, spending time with her family while remaining active in local and traditional leadership.

Legacy

Bai Zenaida's career is the kind that leaves a mark you can still see decades later.

The buildings she built are still standing. The division she shaped is still recognized as a model institution. The educators she mentored have gone on to lead their own schools and offices.

She did all of this while raising seven children, pursuing graduate studies, and carrying the weight of a royal title and community leadership that came with its own set of responsibilities.

Those who worked with her in the Division of Lanao Sur II remember her as firm but caring, principled but human — and that combination, more than any award or infrastructure project, is probably the truest measure of her legacy.

The Bae a Rawaten Award, named for a woman of wisdom worthy of emulation, feels like the right recognition for someone who spent her life being exactly that.

References

Source: Achilles (2025). Tribute speech delivered upon the conferment of the Bae a Rawaten Award to Bai Zenaida Papandayan-Ampatua. KAPRANON, Official Publication of the Division of Lanao Sur II.

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